ELEMENTS OF A CAREER-CONNECTED LEARNING DESIGN

Students develop the knowledge, skills, and experiences needed for future success through four interconnected strands. Each strand contributes distinct opportunities and practices, and together they create a coherent, developmentally sequenced journey that supports students in exploring, preparing for, and transitioning into purposeful college and career pathways.

Academic Integration

Students expand their understanding of how knowledge connects across disciplines and develop transferable skills that prepare them to thrive in diverse fields of work and study.

Advising

Students explore their strengths, interests, and aspirations while charting possible futures with the guidance of trusted adults who encourage and provide support through choices and pivots.

Work-Based Learning

Students are immersed in professional environments where they apply their learning, refine transferable skills, and deepen their understanding of potential career paths through meaningful collaboration with industry partners.

Career & College Preparation Coursework

Students engage in rigorous, future-focused coursework and credential-bearing opportunities that help them access and succeed in postsecondary education and careers.

Student Experience Types	Practices & Activities
Academic Integration Students expand their understanding of how knowledge connects across disciplines and develop transferable skills that prepare them to thrive in diverse fields of work and study.	• Early Exposure to College & Career • Experiential Learning • Guided Inquiry • Entrepreneurial Experiences • Collaborative Discourse • Disciplinary Literacy
Advising Students explore strengths, interests, and aspirations while charting possible futures with the guidance of trusted adults who provide clarity, encouragement, actionable pathways, and support through pivots.	• Self-Exploration • Transition Planning • Mentorship • College Events • Networking
Work-Based Learning Students are immersed in real-world professional environments where they apply their learning, refine transferable skills, and deepen their understanding of potential career paths through meaningful collaboration with industry partners.	• Classroom Jobs • Client Projects • Job Shadowing • Internships • Apprenticeships
Career & College Preparation Coursework Students engage in rigorous, future-focused coursework and credential-bearing opportunities that equip them with the knowledge and qualifications to access and succeed in postsecondary education and careers.	• Dual Enrollment & AP Courses • CTE Courses • Credentialing

ACADEMIC INTEGRATION

Academic Integration weaves rich, imaginative experiences into learning so students absorb knowledge as they actively create, question, and connect.

These experiences:

- Spark curiosity in imaginative ways.
- Cultivate creativity, adaptability, and initiative.
- Strengthen critical thinking and communication through dialogue and collaboration.
- Leverage ways experts read, write, and think to build strong academic and professional foundations.

Student Experience	Description	*Examples*
Early Exposure to College & Career	Young learners are introduced to work and college through proximity and imaginative, play-based experiences that spark curiosity and expand possibilities.	*Books, games, role plays, college posters, themed group categories, and more.*
Experiential Learning	Students deepen understanding through hands-on, real-world learning opportunities that allow them to test ideas, practice problem-solving, and reflect, making learning more relevant and transferable.	*Field trips, service learning, project-based learning, labs, makerspaces, and more.*
Guided Inquiry	Students investigate curiosity-sparking prompts connected to careers through questions, images, or data sets they analyze, interpret, and problem-solve while building career awareness.	*Thought-provoking question, career research, image or dataset to interpret, and more.*
Entrepreneurial Experiences	Hands-on ventures that let students ideate and launch short-term entrepreneurial solutions or enterprises.	*freshINCedu, mxINCedu, INCubatoredu, pop-up markets, and more.*
Collaborative Discourse	Structured conversations that allow students to explore ideas, debate perspectives, and refine their reasoning while working together.	*Rank-Pair-Share, Four Corners, Online Discussion Boards, and more.*
Disciplinary Literacy	Students engage with real-world, subject-specific ways of analyzing information, solving problems, and expressing ideas.	*Budgets, lab reports, business plans, code review commentary, and more.*

ADVISING

Advising creates structured opportunities for students to reflect on who they are and who they might become, supported by trusted adults who provide clarity, encouragement, and guidance.

These experiences:

- Invite self-reflection and discovery of personal strengths, interests, and values.
- Provide planning and guidance for key academic and life transitions.
- Expose students to a wide range of postsecondary options and opportunities.
- Build supportive relationships and social capital through connections with peers, professionals, and broader networks.

Student Experience	Description	*Examples*
Self Exploration	Students engage in assessments that surface passions, strengths, and work styles, giving them and trusted adults clear insights to align plans with evolving interests.	*Card sorts, digital inventories, questionnaires, and more.*
Transition Planning	Students receive milestone-based guidance and personalized coaching to navigate key shifts, such as moving into middle or high school, pathway selection, planning postsecondary launches, and the pivots along the way.	*Individualized plans, college application support, 8th/9th-grade bridge programs, shared academic advising, pathway selection, navigating pivots, and more.*
Mentorship	A trust-based partnership where a learner gains guidance, feedback, and support from an experienced mentor—whether through standalone programs or embedded in internships, pathways, or advisory.	*Mentoring by older peers, alumni, community volunteers, assigned staff, internship supervisors, and more.*
College Events	Structured encounters that immerse students in the possibilities of postsecondary education, from large convention-style fairs to on-campus tours, so they can compare programs, understand admissions, and envision college life.	*College fairs, college visits, and more.*
Networking	Purposeful events and relationship-building activities that connect students with professionals and alumni, expanding their social capital from K-12 through early career.	*Industry-specific pre-professional conferences, on-campus career networking nights, virtual networking, and more.*

WORK-BASED LEARNING

Work-Based Learning immerses students in authentic professional environments where they apply academic knowledge, refine transferable skills, and explore career possibilities through meaningful collaboration with industry partners.

These experiences:

- Provide authentic professional contexts to apply and extend classroom learning.
- Strengthen transferable skills such as problem-solving, collaboration, and communication.
- Offer age-appropriate entry points into the world of work, from classroom jobs to internships.
- Deepen career exploration through direct observation, participation, and reflection in workplace settings.
- Support progression toward future goals through sustained experiences like internships and apprenticeships.

Student Experience	Description	*Examples*
Classroom Jobs	Responsibility-anchored micro-roles that weave learners into the fabric of classroom life, each job with a clear checklist and accountability.	*Line leader, botanist-of-the-week, materials collector, and more.*
Client Projects	Standards-aligned, career-connected learning experiences in which students create authentic deliverables for professional partners.	*Short-term projects, long-term projects, and more.*
Job Shadowing	Students observe professionals in real workplace settings to gain firsthand insight into career roles, workplace expectations, and pathways.	*Half day, full day, meetings, professional events, and more.*
Internships	Students participate in sustained workplace experiences, taking on defined responsibilities, practicing professional habits, and contributing to daily operations. These opportunities provide deeper exposure and a clearer sense of long-term pathways.	*Local, remote (e.g., NASA OSTEM Internship), summer (e.g., Bank of America Student Leaders), and more.*
Apprenticeships	Pairing learners with professionals to build skills through guided practice. For younger students, micro apprenticeships offer short experiences that spark curiosity and early career awareness. For older students, paid apprenticeships provide extended training in a field.	*Micro apprenticeships, National Park Service Junior Ranger Program, AJAC Youth Apprenticeships, and more.*

CAREER & COLLEGE PREPARATION COURSEWORK

Career & College Preparation Coursework challenges students with rigorous, future-focused learning experiences that bridge high school, college, and career.

These experiences:

- Build college readiness through challenging academic courses aligned with postsecondary expectations.
- Develop technical and industry-specific knowledge through career and technical education courses and pathways.
- Provide opportunities to earn recognized credentials and certifications that open doors to careers.
- Strengthen academic persistence, confidence, and preparation for the transition to postsecondary.
- Position students competitively for both college admission and career opportunities.

Student Experience	Description	*Examples*
Dual Enrollment & AP Courses	College-level courses in high school that prepare students for postsecondary success. Dual credit allows students to earn high school and college credit at once, while AP offers rigorous coursework with the chance to earn credit through exams. *Availability depends on local partners as well as state and district policies.*	*Dual Credit, AP, OnRamps, P-TECH, and more.*
CTE Courses	Standalone courses and sequenced pathways help students explore broad career fields and build the knowledge and skills needed for college and the workforce. While standalone courses provide targeted exposure, pathways offer linked coursework that deepens expertise in a specific field. *When designing pathways, consider workforce research as well as state and district policies.*	*Computer Science, Health Sciences, Energy & Sustainable Resources, Graphic Design & Interactive Media, Aerospace Engineering, Construction, and more.*
Credentialing	Industry-recognized certifications or micro-credentials that verify specific technical and professional competencies valued by employers and postsecondary programs.	*OSHA 10 General Industry Safety, CPR/First Aid, ServSafe Food Handler, Adobe Certified Professional, CompTIA A+ or IT Fundamentals, ASE Entry-Level Automotive Service Technician, and more.*